Recently, in an interview with an Arabic news channel, former Pakistan prime minister Shehbaz Sharif expressed his willingness to hold talks with India, saying the two countries cannot be "normal neighbours" unless serious issues are addressed through meaningful discussions. India reiterated its "clear and consistent" position: "We desire normal neighbourly relations with all... including Pakistan. For this, an environment free of terror and hostility is imperative." The respondents of the India Today CVoter Mood of the Nation share similar sentiments, with more than 55 per cent against talks with Pakistan, more than the 52 per cent in January 2023, while 27 per cent believe in talks. Even though Pakistan has been going through political and economic turmoil, Islamabad continues its proxy war by supporting terror attacks on Indian soil.

In June, Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited the United States on a state visit. From transfer of technology in the manufacture of the GE414 fighter jet engine to the MQ-9B drone deal, from the Master Ship Repair Agreement between the US Navy and the L&T Shipyard in Chennai to a NASA-ISRO tie-up, and from collaborations in Quantum and AI technologies and semi-conductors to agreements in duty exemption for Indian steel and aluminium exports, the visit saw a slew of announcements. Clearly, the US is keen on beefing up ties with India. India-US military trade has grown from barely $1 billion (Rs 8,300 crore) in 2008 to over $20 billion (Rs 1.66 lakh crore) now. However, with over 70 per cent of Indian military arsenal being of Russian origin, it will be some time before India stops being dependent on Moscow. Moreover, old ally Russia enjoys considerable goodwill. While 31 per cent of MOTN respondents claim that Russia is India's best friend, 26 per cent feel the US is better for India. Almost 25 per cent support good ties with both the US and Russia.

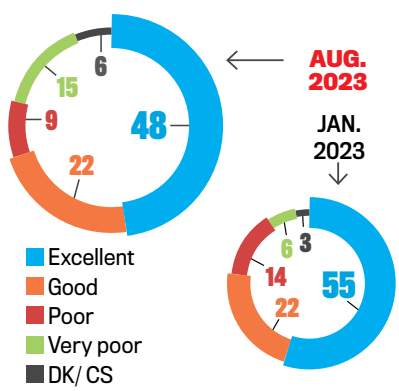
On the Ukraine conflict, India continues to balance its "principles" and its "interests". Without taking sides, India has reiterated that both countries should resolve matters through dialogue, thus cleaving to its age-old non-aligned stand. Indeed, India's strategic interests have not allowed it to directly condemn Russia. Over 51 per cent of the MOTN respondents feel that India adopted the right approach to the conflict, while 25.3 per cent accept it 'to some extent'.

Despite differences over the war in Ukraine, European nations continue to maintain good relations with India—it surely is an acceptance of the Modi government's indepen-

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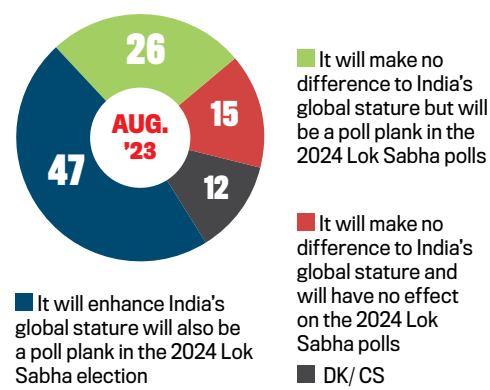


Q. How do you rate the Modi government's foreign policy performance?



The government's foreign policy performance sees a dip but overall remains highly positive

Q. What do you think of India's presidency of the G20?



A majority believe India's G20 presidency will be a poll plank; less than half think it'll enhance our global standing

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: don't know/ can't say